



Grand European

Welcome & Tour Tips

Good to have you here. This page covers the practical things worth knowing before we meet in London.

You do not need to remember everything. Once the tour begins, I'll guide everyone through things step by step.

For official timings, inclusions and documents, please refer to your Trafalgar information.

Before we meet in London



Keep your passport, medication, phone, charger and valuables in your day bag.



Know your London hotel and where we are meeting on departure morning.



Use luggage that rolls easily. We have a short walk through St Pancras before Eurostar.

OUR FIRST DAY



London, Eurostar and Bruges

Our first day is a travel day and a touring day in one. We begin in London, travel by Eurostar to Belgium, and arrive into Bruges in time to begin exploring.



The Eurostar

Our first journey together is the Eurostar from London St Pancras to Belgium — through the Channel Tunnel and into continental Europe.

From Belgium we continue on to Bruges, where the first proper afternoon of the tour begins.



St Pancras

Before boarding, everyone manages their own main suitcase through the terminal: security, UK and French passport control, the departure lounge, and down to the platform. The luggage travels on the train with you.

A suitcase that rolls easily makes this noticeably calmer. A heavy or awkward case can make the terminal feel much longer than it is.

Your Eurostar tickets will be with me — I'll hand them out in the hotel lobby on departure morning. You do not need to print anything in advance.



Dress for the day

Day 1 is a travel day and a sightseeing afternoon in one. Leave your London hotel dressed for both — comfortable shoes especially.

Older European cities are a mix of cobblestones and uneven pavement, and the first afternoon is no exception. Good shoes make a real difference from the very start.



Once we meet

Once we are together, I'll walk everyone through the morning step by step — where to be, what to have ready, and what comes next.

For now, arrive into London knowing your hotel and joining details, with the important things easy to reach.

MUST KNOW



What stays with you

One habit makes departure morning much easier: keep the important things in your day bag, not your main suitcase.



Passport & travel documents

Keep your passport with you on departure morning — do not pack it in your main suitcase. You will need it for Eurostar check-in and immigration at St Pancras.

In Italy, you may be asked to show ID at any time — keep your passport or a clear copy with you on those days.



Day bag essentials

Your main suitcase goes into the coach hold on travel days and may not be accessible until you reach the hotel. Keep anything you might need during the day with you:

- Glasses, contact lenses or hearing aids
- Medication and prescription items
- Phone, charger and any cables
- Cards, cash and travel money
- A light layer or compact waterproof

A useful rule: if you would miss it for a few hours, it belongs in your day bag.

Entry & visa requirements can vary depending on your nationality. Your Trafalgar documents include guidance — I also recommend checking your government's official travel advice before departure to be safe.

GOOD TO KNOW



Before you pack

These are the details that tend to make the biggest practical difference.



Walking shoes

This tour covers a lot of ground: cobblestones, old town centres, viewpoints, station platforms and long sightseeing afternoons.

Comfortable, well-worn shoes make a genuine difference — not just on the first day, but across the whole tour. If you are unsure which pair to bring, bring your most comfortable ones.



Weather and layers

European weather is more variable than many people expect. Northern Europe can be cool and changeable. Switzerland feels noticeably cooler at altitude — even in summer. Southern destinations are warmer, but evenings can still be fresh.

A light packable layer and a compact waterproof solve most situations. Sun protection matters more on this tour than many people plan for — particularly on Alpine days and at outdoor viewpoints.



Power adapters

Most guests on this tour will need at least one adapter. UK plugs are different from continental European plugs — and both are different from most plugs used outside Europe.

Switzerland and Italy can also vary from the standard continental plug, which is why a universal travel adapter with USB and USB-C ports is the simplest solution for the whole tour.

[Power plug guide](#)

Packing

Pack for usefulness rather than volume. Most people bring more than they use — and on a tour with several different hotels, lighter luggage is noticeably easier to live with.

We use audio listening devices on walking tours — disposable wired headphones are provided. These are not Bluetooth, so wireless earbuds will not connect. You are welcome to bring your own wired pair if you prefer.

Luggage allowance: 1 suitcase up to 23kg / 50lbs, plus 1 soft hand-luggage bag. The hand bag must be soft-sided with no wheels or telescopic handle — space on the coach is limited and soft bags fit much more easily. Label both bags clearly before leaving home.

 **Laundry:** On a tour of this length, most people are glad to freshen up the wardrobe somewhere along the way. I'll point out the best opportunity once we are underway.



The rhythm of it

Some days are about movement itself — watching the landscape outside the coach window slowly change as we cross through different parts of Europe. One morning you will be in the Low Countries, by evening looking at Alpine scenery, and a few days later trying to process the beautiful chaos and energy of Italy.

Other days are slower and more about being somewhere properly — old town streets, local guides, viewpoints, long dinners, cafés, cathedrals, and enough time to wander rather than simply ticking places off.

There will be early starts at times, busy breakfast rooms, hotel lobbies full of luggage, changing weather, and long travel days mixed in with quieter ones. That is simply the rhythm of a journey like this.

The cadence of this itinerary is part of what makes it so good. The Low Countries ease you in gently. The Alps shift the scale of things completely. Italy feels louder, busier, more emotional in the best possible way — and then France arrives at the end with a completely different kind of elegance.

We take it step by step. I'll always let you know what's coming up, what's worth having with you for the day, and what you can leave on the coach and not worry about yet.



On the coach

Seat rotation happens daily, and I'll explain the system clearly.

Snacks are absolutely fine. Just avoid hot food, hot drinks and anything likely to melt, spill or perfume the entire coach by lunchtime. Please keep your seat area tidy — it's a shared space and it makes a real difference to everyone's day.

Seatbelts on whenever you are seated — it's a simple habit that matters.

Comfort stops

We plan regular comfort stops along the way. There may also be a WC on board, but most people find the stops easier.

When getting on and off the coach, take your time and use the handrail.

Hotels vary

Some hotels are modern and spacious, others are older or more compact, particularly in historic city centres. That variety is part of the character of a journey like this.

Many European hotels — older properties, mountain hotels and historic buildings in particular — don't have the kind of consistent cooling some guests may be used to. Reception can sometimes help, but a bit of flexibility goes a long way.

Our Driver

Our Driver is a huge part of what makes the journey run smoothly — navigating a coach across multiple countries, border crossings and changing conditions takes real skill.

By the end of the tour, most groups have a genuine appreciation for just how much goes into it.

Tour timings & inclusions

Our days run to a schedule. Being ready on time — for departures, meals and activities — keeps things on track for everyone in the group.

I'll always let you know what's coming up and what to be prepared for. All we ask is that you're there on time, ready to go.

Security

Keep your passport, cards and valuables secure and close to you, especially in busier tourist areas — Rome, Venice and Florence in particular. A small bag that stays close to your body is worth considering for those days.

A little awareness in crowded places goes a long way.

STAYING CONNECTED



WhatsApp

I use WhatsApp for simple reminders and day-to-day updates while we are travelling. It is optional, but it usually makes the small daily details easier.

1

Download and set up WhatsApp before you travel if you do not already use it.

[Download WhatsApp](#)

2

Save my number — it is in your welcome email, or use the WhatsApp link at the top of this page.

3

Send me a message with your name so I know you are set up.

Travelling with someone? It helps if both of you message me, just in case phones get separated during the trip.

Most hotels and many public places offer Wi-Fi.

If you'd rather not use WhatsApp, that's fine — everything important will still reach you.

★ A few practical things for later

You do not need to make all of these decisions before we meet. They become much easier once you can see the pace of the tour and what suits you.

★ Optional experiences

Optional experiences are available throughout the tour, and in my experience they're often the moments that stick — a chance to go a bit further into the places we're already visiting, in a way that's hard to organise on your own.

I'll walk you through everything once we're underway. No pressure at all, but worth keeping an open mind.



Money & cards

Cards are widely accepted, but a small amount of cash can still be useful for smaller cafes, markets, local purchases or gratuities.

London is Pounds Sterling (GBP), but once we are in Europe most countries use the Euro, and Switzerland uses Swiss Franc. For many travellers, small ATM withdrawals are simpler than carrying large amounts from home.



Gratuities

Some gratuities are included in your tour price — portage and restaurant tips on included meals, for example. Tips for your Travel Director and Driver are separate unless pre-paid.

Guidance is in your Trafalgar documents, and you can ask me on tour if you are unsure. This does not need to be solved on the first morning.

CONTACT



Questions before we begin?

Save my contact now, and keep your official joining instructions somewhere easy to find. That is enough for the moment.

Joel Plunkett

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Phone / WhatsApp

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WhatsApp is usually the easiest way to reach me during the trip.

Instagram



Homepage



Email me



Urgent before departure?

Before the tour begins, I may occasionally be travelling or finishing another tour, but I will always get back to you as soon as I can.

If something is time-sensitive before Day 1, please check your welcome email for European Guest Services contact details.

Once we are together, things usually become much more straightforward day to day.



Final note

There's a lot of Europe ahead of us, and I'm looking forward to every part of it. See you in London.

A personal guide from your Travel Director. For official timings, inclusions and operational details, refer to your Trafalgar documents.